

Lesson 5

Building Capacity

In the last lesson I talked about the difference between reacting and responding, and I told you that when you respond over and over while feeling terrible, it's gonna require a skill that most people were never taught. And that skill is distress tolerance. Most people think that healing means that I'm gonna be feeling.

And that makes sense because when you have been suffering for so long, of course you want that suffering to stop. But the skill that actually changed everything for me was not feeling better right away. It was actually getting better at feeling bad. Distress. Tolerance is your capacity to feel discomfort without needing to do something about it.

So I wanna be clear that this isn't about pushing through or ignoring what you're feeling or pretending like Everything is fine, but it is being able to feel something very uncomfortable and let it be there without rushing to fix it. For most of my life, I did not have this. Feeling bad, felt intolerable, and I felt bad all the time, but any uncomfortable sensation felt like it was a signal for me that something was wrong, it needed to be fixed, and that I was always just one hard thing away from falling apart.

I had no room for anything. I had no capacity. That is low distress tolerance. You're living in a state where discomfort feels unbearable, so you'll do anything you have to do to get away from it. Your nervous system is always learning. It's paying attention to what you do when discomfort shows up, and then its job is to draw conclusions based on your behavior.

When you react to discomfort with urgency, like you try to make it stop as fast as you can, your nervous system registers that it learn. Discomfort was dangerous. You couldn't handle it, that the only way to survive it was to get away from it. But when you feel discomfort and you don't react, when you let it be there and you keep living your life, your nervous system will learns something different.

It learns that discomfort was not an emergency, that you can handle it, and that nothing bad happened when you didn't do anything about it. That is how the rewiring happens. Your nervous system learns from your behavior. It does not learn from what you tell yourself. You cannot think your way into safety.

There's no affirmation you can use to convince your system that everything is okay because it is watching what you do. And what you do is what teaches it. Distress tolerance is what allows you to do the thing that teaches your nervous system safety. I wanna be honest with you, like I tend to be about what this process is actually like, because I think a lot of people expect it to feel different than it does.

Building distress. Tolerance is uncomfortable. That is the whole point. You are feeling things you used to run from. Only this time you are not running anymore. So in the beginning, it is going to feel wrong. You are going to have entire days or weeks even where you are convinced you're making a mistake.

This cannot be the path where that urge to go back to all the checking and seeking and figuring out is so strong that you can barely stand it. There's gonna be times where you feel worse than you did before. So you start thinking because your brain is a meaning making machine that maybe this isn't the approach for you.

That is normal. That is what it feels like when you stop feeding that fear and it starts to get louder because it's trying to get your attention. There's also a loneliness to all of this. You feel on your own because no one understands what you're going through and no matter what anyone else does, when they try to make you feel better.

They can't. That is very isolating. You're gonna doubt yourself a lot. You are going to wonder if it is working. You're gonna have setbacks where you react and then you feel like you ruined everything and like you're back to square one, but you didn't ruin anything. And it's very important that you don't see this as pass or fail because it's not how this kind of stuff works.

You are building capacity over time, and I know it's corny and cheesy, but it's like building a muscle. You would not go into the gym and do one set of bicep curls and think that you should have big arms. Now, it's just not how it works. Some days you're gonna have more capacity. Some days you're gonna have less, but I want you to always focus on what.

Direction am I going? Because that matters more than any single moment. So if you have a moment where you don't respond in the way you want to, or you have a week where you fall off, course that doesn't matter. Ultimately, what is the direction you are moving in and how often can you course correct to keep moving in that direction?

'cause you're gonna end up where you wanna be sooner or later. The question is how often are we veering off course? And more importantly, how quickly can we get back on. A lot of nervous system content out there is really focused on calming down, getting you back to baseline and using different tools to shift how you feel.

And I wanna address that here because those tools are not bad. Especially if you're just dealing with dysregulation. But when you are sensitized, they can easily become another way to escape discomfort and another form of reaction. So you may be tempted to to pile on some other tools and be like, well, I think this helps.

And maybe meditation and maybe visualization and maybe journaling. And again, there isn't really a right or wrong, it's just are you using this thing in this moment? To get away from how you feel, because if you use them in that way, you aren't building capacity. You're reinforcing the idea that you can't handle the activation.

You're feeling right now that this discomfort is dangerous and that you need it to go away before you can be, okay. So let's journal it away. Let's meditate it away. Let's visualize it away. Let's interrupt it away. That is a way of looking at what you're experiencing and saying. This can't be here and I need to use a tool to change it.

It's so important that your nervous system learns that you are okay even when the discomfort does not stop, and it cannot learn that if every time you feel bad, you reach for a tool to make that feeling go away. Later on down the road, you're gonna be doing so much better. You're gonna be desensitized.

You may deal with some mild dysregulation sometimes, and you may decide that you want a meditation practice. That's fabulous. I love that for you. That's what I do. I love it, but I don't do it. To make anything go away. This is why I do not teach breathing exercises or grounding techniques or somatic tools in this course, because for a sensitized system, they often just become another thing that you reach for.

When you're scared and you're uncomfortable. It's another way to avoid feeling what you're feeling. The thing that builds distress tolerance is feeling the feeling. That is it. Here's something important. You are not gonna feel better right away, okay? That's not the sign that it's working. There are gonna be early signs though that are gonna be more subtle, and I do want you to watch for these signs because you might notice I didn't react to something that previously would've sent you completely spiraling.

And you realize it's just because I didn't engage with it, that is a huge win. You might notice that a bad morning that used to automatically lead to a bad day is not happening anymore. You're, you realize I can feel crappy and I can still do things. You might notice that that. Constant urgency has softened.

Maybe it's not gone, but it's softened just a little, and the sensations are still there, but you just don't have this desperate need to make them stop. You might also notice that you're spending less time thinking about and focusing on your symptoms. They're still there. They go up and down, but they're not the center of your attention all day long.

These are very, very real signs of progress. It's not necessarily feeling good, but it's feeling less controlled by feeling bad. Once I decided I was gonna feel bad while still doing things I enjoyed, like once I stopped waiting to feel better before I lived my life, I started noticing a huge shift. It wasn't super fast, but over time I just realized I'm responding completely differently to things.

And you know, I had to put a lot of effort into that in the beginning. But the cool thing about neuroplasticity and your brain's ability to change is that once you start firing those circuits more and more on purpose. Choosing to respond in a new way, that new way of responding becomes your default.

That's the magic of all of this. In fact, a few months into my very serious decision to take recovery very seriously, was I, my 6-year-old had to get her tonsils out. Now this was outpatient, but she still

was six years old and went under anesthesia and she woke up in a rough state, and then it was probably 11 or 12 days of a lot of pain for her trouble sleeping, restlessness, irritability, and before.

That would've absolutely wrecked me. Combining the stress, the overstimulation, the worry. I would've been anxious the whole time my symptoms would've spiked. I would've been spiraling about how I wasn't gonna be able to sleep. But I wasn't anxious. I was present with her. I slept with her, and I felt fine.

I felt resourced. And then another thing I realized was I was able to travel again. I started taking trips that would've been unthinkable six months earlier. I. And the anxiety and the symptoms that used to stop me and take over how I was feeling and thinking they were barely there. That didn't require me to work through every single fear I had, but.

It was a sure sign that my capacity had really grown. I could handle discomfort without it derailing me, and I was able to even have some fun in the mix of all that. That is what capacity feels like. It doesn't mean you avoid doing hard things. It means that you have the ability to actually meet those things.

This is why stopping the reactive behaviors worked so well for me because when I stopped reacting, my nervous system finally had the chance to learn something new. It's what I had always wanted the whole time. I wanted my nervous system to do this, learn that I could handle discomfort, learn that nothing catastrophic is going to happen.

Even when I didn't do anything about it. Distress tolerance builds capacity, and capacity is what will help you finally live your life again. Building distress tolerance is not fun. It is not fast, and there is no way to skip over it. If you do try to skip over it, you're just gonna keep ending up in the same place because you have not got better at feeling, but it's also simpler than it seems.

You feel the feeling you don't react. You let life keep going. The next lesson is about what to expect as you do this work because it often gets harder before it gets easier, and I don't want you to be caught off guard when that happens.

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